8.3.6 Lightning

Lightning is an atmospheric electrostatic discharge (spark) accompanied by thunder, which typically occurs during thunderstorms, and sometimes during volcanic eruptions or dust storms. Lightning generates 10-20 ampere current and it is therefore fatal. It is especially dangerous for people in an open area.



- You can hear thunder from about 16 km of its starting point.
- Lightning bolts travel at the speed of up to 80,000 km / second.
- The average length of a single lightning bolt is 3-4km.

Lightning strikes often have fatal consequences. On an average, 2000 people die from lightning in the world every year. Lightning mostly strikes tall things, such as trees that break down and catch fire or it may strike power transmission lines and antennas fastened on roofs and buildings which causing fire. The air temperature, when lightning occurs, is as hot as 9982.2 °C.

Thunder is the sound caused by lightning. A charged, superheated lightning bolt creates a "resonating tube" as it travels. The air in the tube rapidly expands and contracts causing vibrations that we hear as the rumble of thunder.



Lightning strikes can explode a tree. Imagine 15 million volts of electricity hitting a tree branch. The heat travels through the tree, vaporizing its sap and creating steam that causes the trunk to explode.



- Lightning flashes more than 3 million times a day or 40 times a second worldwide.
- An average lightning bolt can release enough energy to operate a 100-watt light bulb for more than three months straight (about 250 kilowatt-hours of energy).

Before lightning

1. If you are planning to go to the countryside, check the weather forecast.
2. If a thunderstorm is expected it is better to postpone the trip.
3. It is good if you can estimate the distance to the front line of a thunderstorm. In order to do this you must check the time interval from the moment you see the lightning until you hear thunder. Lightning always precedes thunder. We know that the sound speed travels on average about 1km every 3 seconds. Reduction of the time interval between the sight of lightning and the resulting thunder means that the danger is approaching and protective measures must be taken. If there is no interval between lightning and thunder means, it means that the cloud is already over your head.

During Lightning:

1. If you are in a building it is necessary to close windows, doors, ventilation pipes and chimneys.

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